

Freedom from obesity

On the **occasion** of Independence Day, Prime Minister Narendra Modi did well to **flag** the growing obesity problem, and the need to **break free** of it by eating more **sensibly** — consuming and buying 10 per cent less oil, **perhaps to begin with**. **Obesity**, defined in terms of **abdominal** fat and body mass index (BMI), **has** been **rapidly on the rise**, bringing with it the risk of diabetes, **hypertension** and **susceptibility** to **cardiovascular**, kidney disease and cancer.

It would be a **fallacy** to believe that only the really rich are **obese** or that, as a **corollary**, non-communicable diseases (NCDs) **afflict** only **the well-to-do**. **Covid**, being **lethal** for those with NCDs, **should** have **upended** these **stereotypes**. A 2023 Lancet paper on abdominal obesity analyses National Family Health Survey-5 (2019-21 data) to show that obesity measured by **waist circumference** as well as BMI is high for a country where malnutrition is **widespread**. Surprisingly, 40 per cent of women are reported to be abdominally obese (with a waist circumference of above 80 cm), while the figure for men is much lower at 12 per cent (waist circumference below 94 cm). The BMI levels are more similar for women and men, at 23 per cent and 22.1 per cent, respectively. Abdominal fat can **lead to** health **complications**, even if the BMI is within limits.

The **apparent correlation** between this data and the **incidence** of NCDs **does** not come as a surprise. According to a recent paper on NCDs in Bihar, **hosted** on the website of the National Library of Medicine, the **incidence** of hypertension in women aged 35-49 **was** 17 per cent according to NFHS-5, and 21.5 per cent among men aged 35-54 years. It observes that NCDs have been on the rise both in developed and ruralised States. Rising NCDs among the less well-to-do **calls for** both a preventive and **curative** response. They are 'silent killers'. Their treatment can be both **tardy** and expensive. **Diagnostics** at district level clinics **must** be looked into, with the role of 'Ayushman Bharat' or similar schemes being **assessed in this regard**. But **NCDs**, as the Prime Minister has urged, **have** to be prevented. Apart from consuming less oil (particularly unhealthy palm oil) and sugar, it is also important to ensure that packaged foods and dishes **rustled up** in hotels and restaurants **meet** certain standards.

The CBSE's sugar awareness push in schools is a step in the right direction. **Oils** from sources **endemic** to the country such as groundnut, sesame, coconut and mustard **must** be promoted over imported ones such as palm oil. The FSSAI must check for purity in sunflower, groundnut and coconut oil, besides following up on its **mandate** to make package labelling specific, **legible** and accurate. Working India eats on the move, and **to this end** it is important that fresh meals are provided by the government (as with Amma canteens experiment in Tamil Nadu under the AIADMK regime). India needs to live and eat differently, and the **onus** for making this happen **lies** both on citizens and governments.

[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

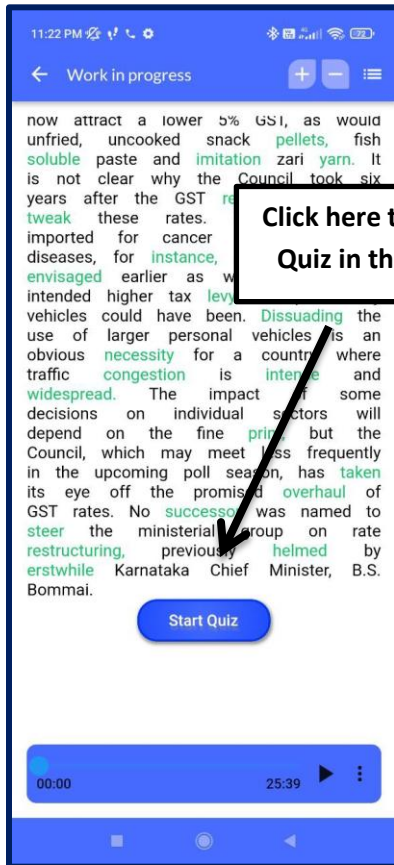
1. **Obesity** (noun) – adiposity, corpulence, excessive weight, overfatness, high BMI
मोटापा
2. **Flag** (verb) – highlight, signal, spotlight, draw attention to, point out उजागर करना
3. **Break free** (phrase) – escape, shake off, get out of, liberate oneself, cast off मुक्त होना
4. **Sensibly** (adverb) – wisely, prudently, judiciously, reasonably, thoughtfully
समझदारी से
5. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, arguably, perchance शायद
6. **To begin with** (phrase) – initially, at first, to start with, at the outset, for a start शुरू में
7. **Abdominal** (adjective) – belly, central, visceral, midsection, waistline-related पेट-संबंधी
8. **Rapidly** (adverb) – quickly, swiftly, briskly, speedily, fast तेजी से
9. **Be on the rise** (phrase) – increase, grow, climb, trend up, ascend बढ़ रहा है
10. **Hypertension** (noun) – high blood pressure, elevated BP, arterial hypertension, raised pressure, high BP
उच्च रक्तचाप
11. **Susceptibility** (to) (noun) – vulnerability, proneness, predisposition, liability, sensitivity संवेदनशीलता
12. **Cardiovascular** (adjective) – cardiac, heart-related, circulatory, CV, heart-and-vessel
हृदय-धमनी संबंधी
13. **Fallacy** (noun) – misconception, myth, error, false belief, mistaken notion भ्रम
14. **Obese** (adjective) – overweight, corpulent, fat, adipose, heavysset मोटापा ग्रस्त
15. **Corollary** (noun) – consequence, result, by-product, follow-on, outcome परिणामस्वरूप निष्कर्ष
16. **Afflict** (verb) – plague, torment, beset, burden, trouble पीड़ित करना
17. **The well-to-do** (noun) – the affluent, the rich, the prosperous, the better-off, moneyed classes समृद्ध वर्ग
18. **Lethal** (adjective) – deadly, fatal, life-threatening, mortal, pernicious घातक
19. **Upend** (verb) – overturn, topple, upturn, subvert, disrupt उलट देना
20. **Stereotype** (noun) – cliché, generalization, typecast, received idea, caricature रूढ़िबद्ध धारणा

21. **Waist** (noun) – waistline, midriff, midsection, middle, torso's narrow part
कमर
22. **Circumference** (noun) – girth, perimeter, encircling measure, outline, circuit परिधि
23. **Widespread** (adjective) – prevalent, pervasive, extensive, rampant, far-reaching
व्यापक
24. **Lead** (to) (verb) – result in, cause, bring about, give rise to, usher in का कारण बनना
25. **Complication** (noun) – problem, difficulty, setback, adverse effect, sequela जटिलता
26. **Apparent** (adjective) – evident, obvious, clear, manifest, noticeable स्पष्ट
27. **Correlation** (noun) – link, association, relationship, connection, interrelation
सहसंबंध
28. **Incidence** (noun) – occurrence, rate, frequency, prevalence, proportion घटनादर
29. **Host** (verb) – publish, post, carry, feature, house (online) प्रकाशित करना
30. **Call for** (phrasal verb) – demand, require, necessitate, warrant, ask for मांग करना
31. **Curative** (adjective) – therapeutic, healing, remedial, restorative, medicinal
उपचारात्मक
32. **Tardy** (adjective) – delayed, late, sluggish, dilatory, slow देरी से
33. **Assess** (verb) – evaluate, appraise, gauge, examine, review आकलन करना
34. **In this regard** (phrase) – in this respect, in this context, on this front, regarding this, about this इस संबंध में
35. **Rustle up** (phrasal verb) – prepare quickly, whip up, throw together, knock together, put together जल्दी बना लेना
36. **Meet** (verb) – satisfy, fulfill, comply with, match, live up to पूरा करना
37. **Endemic** (adjective) – native, indigenous, homegrown, local, domestic स्वदेशी/
स्थानिक
38. **Mandate** (noun) – directive, instruction, order, authorization, requirement आदेश
39. **Legible** (adjective) – readable, clear, decipherable, distinct, neat पढ़ने योग्य
40. **To this end** (phrase) – for this purpose, with this aim, to that end, toward this, in pursuit of this इसी उद्देश्य से
41. **Onus** (noun) – responsibility, burden, duty, obligation, charge दायित्व
42. **Lie** (verb) – rest, reside, devolve, fall on, be with निहित होना

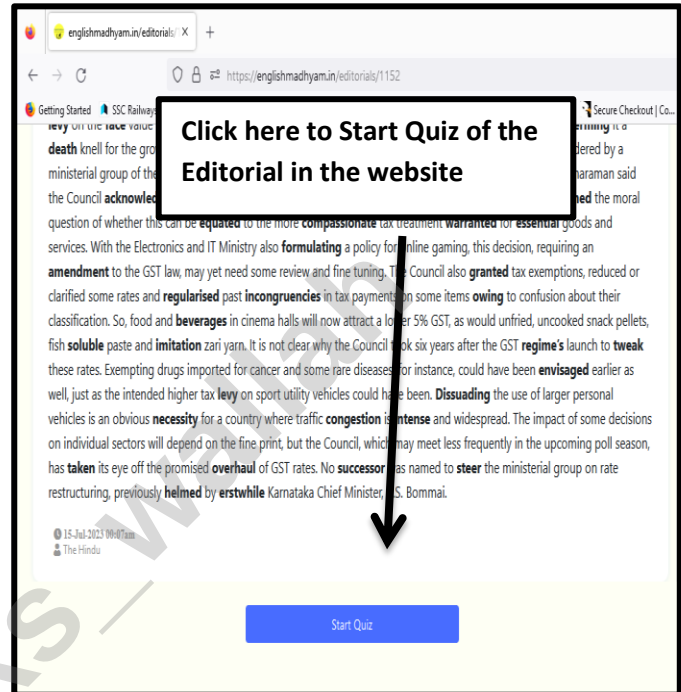
Summary of the Editorial

1. On Independence Day, Prime Minister Modi highlighted obesity as a growing national health issue.
2. He suggested starting by reducing oil consumption and purchase by 10% as a preventive step.
3. Obesity, defined by abdominal fat and BMI, is rapidly increasing in India.
4. It raises risks of diabetes, hypertension, cardiovascular, kidney diseases, and cancer.
5. It is a myth that obesity and non-communicable diseases (NCDs) affect only the rich.
6. Covid-19 exposed how people with NCDs are especially vulnerable, breaking such stereotypes.
7. A 2023 Lancet paper using NFHS-5 data shows obesity levels are high despite widespread malnutrition.
8. Around 40% of women are abdominally obese, compared to 12% of men.
9. BMI-based obesity rates are similar across genders — 23% for women and 22.1% for men.
10. Abdominal obesity can cause serious health issues even when BMI is within limits.
11. Data from Bihar shows hypertension rates rising: 17% among women (35–49 years) and 21.5% among men (35–54 years).
12. NCDs are increasing across both rich and rural/less-developed states, demanding preventive and curative responses.
13. Treatment of NCDs is slow and costly, making preventive action crucial.
14. Measures include reducing palm oil and sugar intake, promoting traditional oils, and ensuring food safety and labeling.
15. Government initiatives like school sugar awareness drives, FSSAI monitoring, and affordable canteen schemes are key, but citizens too must change eating habits.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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